Bartholomew and the Oobleck

By Theo Geisel (aka Dr. Seuss)

NARRATOR: They still talk about it in the Kingdom of Didd as The-Year-the-King-got-Angry-with-the-Sky. If it hadn't been for Bartholomew Cubbins, that King and that Sky would have wrecked that little Kingdom.

INTRODUCTION

In an age when power is often mistaken for entitlement, this story feels less like a children's fable and more like a warning etched in green slime. King Derwin's insistence that even the sky should bend to his will echoes a dangerous change in modern governance -- where leaders test the limits of institutions, sidestep norms, and treat politics as something to command rather than uphold. When a leader begins to see themselves not as a servant of their people but as an all-powerful, untouchable authority, our way of life is doomed. Can the kingdom be saved? Only if ordinary people, institutions, and officials speak plainly and insist, without fear, that no one, however powerful, rules the sky.

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KING: *(staring up into the sky, muttering and sputtering)* Humph! The things that come down from ***my*** sky!

NARRATOR: All spring when the rain came down, he growled at ***that*** . . . All summer when the sunshine came down, he growled at ***that***. . . All Autumn when the fog came down, he growled at ***that*** . . . And that winter when the snow came down, he started shouting!

KING: This snow! This Fog! This Sunshine! This rain! BAHH!

BARTHOLOMEW: *(trying to calm him)* But, King Derwin, you've ***always*** had these same four things.

KING: *(bellowing)* That's just the trouble! Every year the ***same*** four things! I want something NEW to come down!"

BARTHOLOMEW: Something ***new***? That's impossible, Your Majesty.

KING: Boy, don't you dare tell me what I can or cannot have! I am King!

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BARTHOLOMEW: I know, Sire, you rule all the land. And you rule all the people. But even kings can't rule the ***sky***.

KING: *(flying into a terrible rage)* Well, maybe ***other*** kings can't do it, but maybe I'm one king who can! *(begins laughing)* ***They*** can do it for me! Bartholomew Cubbins, call my royal magicians!

BARTHOLOMEW: *(shivering)* Oh, no, Your Majesty! Don't call them!

KING: Hold your tongue, Bartholomew Cubbins! You do as I command you.

BARTHOLOMEW: *(bowing)* Yes, Sire. But, Your Majesty, you may be very sorry.

NARRATOR: He took the King's secret whistle from its hook. He blew a long, low blast down the King's stairway. And a moment later he heard them coming!

MAGICIANS: *(shuffling and chanting)*
Shuffle, duffle, muzzle, muff.
Fista, wista, mista-cuff.
We are men of groans and howls,
Mystic men who eat boiled owls.
Tell us what you wish, oh King.
Our magic can do anything.

KING: I wish to have you make something fall from my skies that no other kingdom has ever had before. What can you do? What will you make?

MAGICIANS: (thinking, blinking) . . . Oobleck.
Won't look like rain. Won't look like snow.
Won't look like fog. That's all we know.
We just can't tell you any more.
We've never made Oobleck before.

BARTHOLOMEW: *(whispering)* They'll do something crazy, Your Majesty! Stop them!

KING: *(chuckling)* Stop them? Not for a ton of diamonds! Why, I'll be the mightiest man that ever lived! Tomorrow I'm going to have OOBLECK!

NARRATOR: On the Mystic Mountain Neeka-tave the magicians were working their terrible magic. All night they walked circles round their magic fire . . .

MAGICIANS: *(chanting)*
Oh, snow and rain are not enough!
Oh, we must make some brand-new stuff!
Burn yellow twigs and burn red rust

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And burn a stocking full of dust.
Make magic smoke, green, thick and hot!
(It sure smells dreadful, does it not?)
Go, magic smoke! Go high! Go high!
Go rise into the kingdom's sky!
Go make the wondrous Oobleck fall!
Oh, bring down Oobleck on us all!

NARRATOR: Dawn was breaking and Bartholomew was still watching at the bedchamber window. There was something strange in the sky! At first it seemed like a little greenish cloud . . . just a wisp of greenish steam. Tiny little greenish specks were shimmering in the air right over his head.

BARTHOLOMEW: *(stretching out his hand to catch a speck, the pulls his hand back, frightened. Slams the window shut, shouting)* Wake up, Your majesty! Your oobleck! It's falling!

KING: *(springs from his bed)* By my royal whiskers, it is! Oh, that beautiful oobleck! And it's mine! All mine!

BARTHOLOMEW: I don't like the looks of those blobs, Sire. They're coming down now as big as greenish peanuts.

KING: *(laughing)* The bigger the better! Oh, what a day! I'm going to make it a holiday! I want everyone in my kingdom to go out and dance in my glorious oobleck!

BARTHOLOMEW: Do you really think it's safe, Sire?

KING: *(snapping)* Stop asking foolish questions! Wake my royal bell ringer. Tell him to ring the great holiday bell! Run!

NARRATOR: Across the sleeping palace, Bartholomew ran. Then up the ladder of the high bell tower.

BARTHOLOMEW: Ring your bell! His majesty proclaims today a holiday!

BELL RINGER: *(grabbing the bell rope and yanking – Nothing happens. He yanks harder – still nothing)* Heh . . .? What's wrong with my bell? I'd better take a look outside. *(pokes his head out through the little trap door)* Merciful gracious! What is THAT? All over my bell like greenish molasses!

BARTHOLOMEW: Not only your bell! Look at that poor robin down there in that tree!

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She's stuck to her nest! That oobleck's like glue!

BELL RINGER: *(wringing his hands)* Oooh! If that green stuff sticks up robins, it'll stick up people, too!"

BARTHOLOMEW: Someone's got to warn the people! Warn 'em to stay inside their houses! I'll tell the royal trumpeter! *(races off)*

NARRATOR: But all the royal trumpeter blew was . . .

TRUMPETER: *(blowing on his trumpet*: *GLUGG!)* My horn! One of those green things flew inside it! *(tries to blow it out; tries to shake it out, but no success)* I'll pull it out!

BARTHOLOMEW: No! Don't you touch it!

NARRATOR: [But] The trumpeter's hand was already in it.

TRUMPETER: *(grabs hold of the lump of oobleck; pulls with all his might. The oobleck stretches then snaps back inside the trumpet, yanking his arm back with it)* I can't wiggle a finger! Oh, Bartholomew, what'll I do?

BARTHOLOMEW: I hate to leave you stuck to your horn. But if you can't warn the people of the kingdom, I've got to find someone who can! *(races out)*

NARRATOR: Down the stairs raced Bartholomew Cubbins . . . down to the chamber of the Captain of the Guards.

CAPTAIN: *(humming in front of his mirror, combing the ends of his moustache)*

BARTHOLOMEW: Captain! DO something! Haven't you seen the dreadful Oobleck?"

CAPTAIN: *(nonchalantly laughing)* Oh, that stuff. What so dreadful about that? I think it's rather pretty. That stuff's harmless. I'll show you. I'll eat some. *(leans out the window, scooping up some oobleck)*

BARTHOLOMEW: Don't, Captain! DON'T!

NARRATOR: The Captain did! By the time Bartholomew dragged him back inside the room . . .

CAPTAIN: *(mouth glued shut with oobleck. Tries to speak, but no words come out)*

BARTHOLOMEW: Forgive me for leaving you, Captain . . . *(races out)* I'll get the King's horse! I'll ride through the country! I'll warn the people of the kingdom myself!

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NARRATOR: He pushed open the door that led to the Royal Stables. The awful oobleck was plumping down as big as greenish footballs now! Too late to warn the people of the kingdom! There were farmers in the fields, getting stuck to hoes and plows. Goats were getting stuck to ducks. Geese were getting stuck to cows. It was piling up, great greenish tons of Oobleck, deeper and deeper on every roof in the land. There was nothing Bartholomew Cubbins could do out there.

BARTHOLOMEW: *(shaking his head sadly, he steps back inside)*

NARRATOR: But inside, a moment later, it was just as bad as out! With an angry roar, the Oobleck was suddenly hitting the palace harder! The whole palace was springing leaks. It was dripping through the ceilings. It was coming in everywhere . . . even through the keyholes!

BARTHOLOMEW: *(gasping)* The King!

NARRATOR: Where was the King? He'd forgotten all about him! Bartholomew found him in the throne room. There he sat . . . Old King Derwin, proud and might ruler of the Kingdom of Did, helpless as a baby. His royal crown was stuck to his head. The seat of his royal pants were stuck to his throne. Oobleck was dripping from his royal eyebrows.

KING: Fetch my magicians, Bartholomew! Make them say some magic words to stop the oobleck falling!

BARTHOLOMEW: *(shrugging his shoulders)* I can't, Your Majesty. Their cave on Mountain Neeka-tave is buried deep in oobleck.

KING: *(groaning)* Then I must think of some magic words! Oh, what are those words my magicians say . . . ? Shuffle. . . duffle . . . muzzle . . . muff . . . That's all I can remember and they don't do any good! The oobleck keeps on falling harder!"

BARTHOLOMEW: *(angry)* And it's going to keep falling until your great palace tumbles down! Don't waste your time saying foolish magic words. YOU ought to be saying some plain simple words! This is all your fault! Now the least you can do is say, "I'm sorry."

KING: *(belligerent -- no one had ever talked to him like this before)* What! ME . . . ME say I'm sorry! Kings never say I'm sorry! And I am the mightiest king in all the world!

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BARTHOLOMEW: *(not backing down)* You may be a mighty king. but you're sitting in Oobleck up to your chin. And so is everyone else in your land. If you won't even say you're sorry, you're no sort of a king at all! *(turns his back to leave)*

KING: *(great, deep sob, he begins crying)* Come back, Bartholomew Cubbins. You're right! It is all my fault! And I am sorry!

NARRATOR: And the moment the King spoke those words, something happened. . . Maybe there was something magic in those simple words, "I'm sorry." Maybe there was something magic in those simple words, "It's all my fault." Maybe there was, and maybe there wasn't. But they say that as soon as the old King spoke them, the sun began to shine. They say that all the oobleck just simply, quietly melted away.

Then the King proclaimed a new national holiday . . . in honor of the four perfect things that come down from the sky: The rain, the sunshine, the fog and the snow.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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